weak spot. In all this changing of schools, education systems and countries, I was lucky not to lose a year.

I had a great time at Bishop's. I was in Arnold House, which at that time was the champion house, and I remember participating in the cross-country run at the Racecourse! Every Saturday, we used to get some pocket money, Rs 2 for my brother, and Rs 1.50 for me. That was quite adequate for small treats: an ice lolly was 15 paise and a cream roll 20 paise. There were different hostels for different age groups and I was in Simba Hostel, just across the road and adjoining the playground. It was here that I was introduced to cricket, as in France we used to play only football. Hostel life also made one more independent and self-sufficient—making your own bed, looking after your personal hygiene, studies and homework; there was no one to mother you. Once a week, we had to compulsorily write a letter home, to let our parents know of our well-being. This was a chore most of us just wanted to get over with, so that we could go out and play. My letters home were quite perfunctory, 'My Dear Mummy and Daddy', I would start, 'How are you? I am well', and end with, 'More in my next, love Manoj.' There was never 'more' ever, except perhaps on one occasion when my brother and I had had a fight and I thought he might 'sneak' to my parents. That week's letter had an additional sentence, 'Don't believe whatever Nitin says.' The schoolmasters used to carry a wooden paddle about the size of a table tennis bat, called a 'flat'. For any misdemeanour, we would be called to the front of the class, asked to bend down and receive 'six of the best' on our posterior. I too got my share of 'sixes', usually for not doing my homework. This was a very harrowing experience and it is a good thing that corporal punishment has been banned by law.

During the weekend, we were allowed to go overnight to our local guardians, in our case, our grandparents Ai-Dada. Sadly,

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